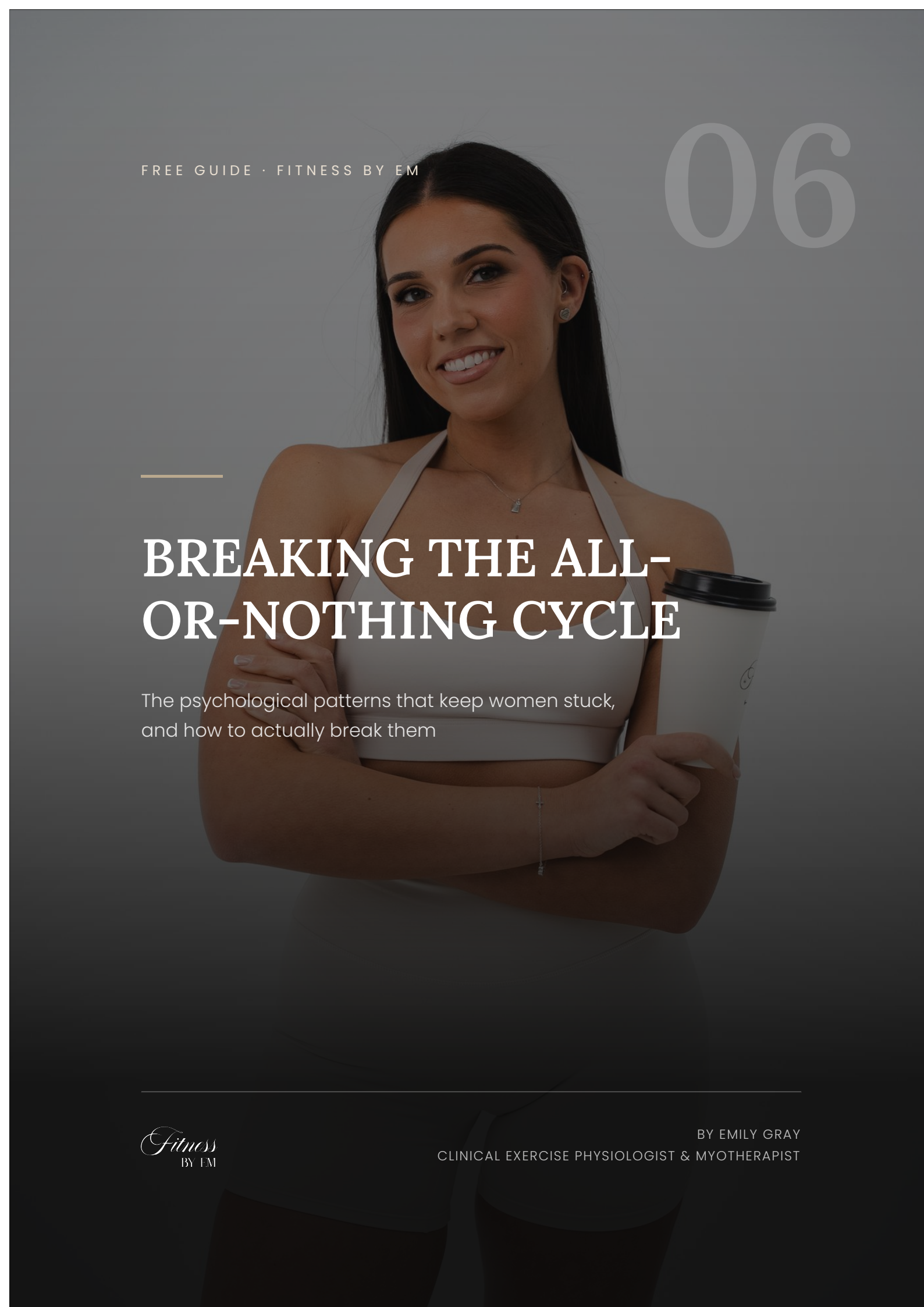
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BREAKING THE ALL-OR-NOTHING CYCLE

The psychological patterns that keep women stuck, and how to actually break them

Fitness BY EM

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MINDSET · ALL LEVELS

BREAKING THE ALL-OR-NOTHING CYCLE

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80/20	0	450+
THE STANDARD THAT LASTS	PERFECT WEEKS REQUIRED	WOMEN COACHED

Introduction

You know the pattern. You start strong on Monday. Everything's on track for a few days, sometimes longer. Then one meal goes "off plan," or one workout gets missed, and something in your head decides the whole week is ruined. So you stop trying entirely, tell yourself you'll restart next Monday, and the cycle repeats.

This pattern, all-or-nothing thinking, is one of the biggest reasons women who are genuinely capable of sustainable change stay stuck in a loop of starting over. It's not a discipline problem. It's a thinking pattern, and thinking patterns can be identified and changed.

This guide walks through where this pattern comes from, how it plays out, and the practical shifts that actually break it, for good, not just until the next Monday.

1. Where All-Or-Nothing Thinking Comes From

All-or-nothing thinking (sometimes called black-and-white thinking) is a cognitive pattern where things are categorised into two extremes, perfect or failed, on-plan or off-plan, good or bad, with no middle ground acknowledged.

In the context of food and fitness, this pattern is heavily reinforced by diet culture itself. Most commercial diets are built on rigid rules, foods that are "allowed" and foods that are "banned," which trains your brain to see any deviation as a rule violation rather than as a normal, expected part of a flexible life. The stricter and more rule-based a diet is, the more likely it is to produce this exact thinking pattern in the people who follow it.

Perfectionism plays a role too. If your internal standard is 100% adherence, anything less than that can feel like failure, even when 90% or 80% adherence would still produce excellent, real-world results.

Understanding where this pattern came from matters, because it makes clear that it's learned, not innate. And what's learned can be unlearned.

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2. The Restrict-Binge Cycle

One of the most common expressions of all-or-nothing thinking is the restrict-binge cycle, a pattern that tends to look like this:

A period of strict restriction (an extreme calorie deficit, entire food groups eliminated, rigid rules) is followed by a moment where willpower runs out, often triggered by intense hunger, stress, or simply exhaustion from maintaining the restriction. This produces an episode of eating that feels out of control, frequently involving foods that were labelled "off-limits." That episode then triggers guilt and shame, which is frequently followed by an even stricter return to restriction as a form of self-punishment, setting the entire cycle up to repeat.

The uncomfortable truth is that the restriction itself is usually what sets up the binge, not a lack of discipline in the moment. Extreme rules create the exact psychological and physiological conditions (intense hunger, deprivation, mental preoccupation with "forbidden" food) that make a binge far more likely. Removing the extreme restriction removes much of what's driving the cycle in the first place.



and the cycle repeats, until the pattern itself is interrupted

3. The "Starting Over Every Monday" Pattern

Many women live in a cycle of mentally "starting fresh" every Monday, treating any inconsistency during the week as evidence that this attempt has failed and a new, better attempt needs to begin.

The problem with this pattern is that it turns a single missed workout or one indulgent meal into an entire lost week, simply because of when it happened relative to an arbitrary weekly reset point. A Wednesday setback doesn't need to wait until the following Monday to be addressed, it can be addressed on Thursday.

This pattern also creates a strange incentive: because "the diet starts Monday," there's often a subconscious push to eat everything you're "giving up" over the weekend beforehand, a last supper mentality that actually works against the goal before the new attempt has even begun.

Breaking this pattern means removing the concept of a symbolic restart day altogether. There is no meaningful difference between a Wednesday and a Monday, the next meal, whenever it happens to be, is always the next opportunity to make a good choice, regardless of the day of the week or what happened at the meal before it.

4. The Single Most Important Reframe

If there's one idea to take from this entire guide, it's this: one inconsistent meal, workout, or day does not undo progress. It's the spiral of turning one off-plan moment into a lost week, then a lost month, that actually derails results, not the original moment itself.

> *One inconsistent meal does not undo progress. The spiral you build around it does.*

Picture two women who both eat a large, indulgent meal on a Tuesday. One treats it as a single meal and returns to her normal pattern at the next meal. The other treats it as proof the week (and sometimes the whole attempt) is ruined, and stops trying entirely until the following Monday. Six months later, the physiological impact of that one Tuesday meal is identical for both of them, but their actual outcomes will be dramatically different, entirely because of how they responded to it, not because of the meal itself.

Progress was never meant to be a straight line. Every sustainable long-term result is actually built from a slightly messy, inconsistent, very human pattern of mostly-good weeks with the occasional off day scattered through them, not from twelve weeks of flawless perfection.

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5. Practical Strategies To Break The Cycle

Redefine what "on track" actually means. Instead of defining a good week as 100% perfect adherence, redefine it as roughly 80% consistency. This single mindset shift removes the all-or-nothing trap almost entirely, because near-misses no longer count as failures.

Use the "next meal" rule. Whatever happened at your last meal, your very next meal is simply an opportunity to eat well, regardless of what came before it. There's no need to wait for tomorrow, or Monday, or any symbolic restart point.

Remove "forbidden" food labels. Foods framed as entirely off-limits tend to become mentally magnified and more likely to trigger a binge when you do eventually eat them. Allowing all foods a place, in appropriate portions and contexts, tends to reduce their psychological pull over time.

Separate a single choice from your identity. "I ate something off my plan" is a factual, neutral statement about one moment. "I failed" or "I have no discipline" is an identity-level judgement that tends to trigger the shame-restriction cycle. Practise noticing the difference and consciously choosing the neutral framing.

Track consistency, not perfection. If you're tracking your progress at all, track how many days out of seven you did something aligned with your goals, rather than whether every single day was flawless. This naturally reinforces an 80/20 mindset rather than an all-or-nothing one.

Give yourself permission to have an imperfect week without it meaning anything about your character, your discipline, or your ability to eventually reach your goal. An imperfect week is data, not a verdict.

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6. What Sustainable Actually Looks Like

Sustainable weight loss and sustainable fitness rarely look like the polished, linear transformation often shown in marketing. In reality, it looks like a genuinely good week, followed by an average week, followed by a great week, followed by a week disrupted by a cold or a work deadline, followed by a return to a good week again. Across months, that pattern still produces real, lasting results, because the good weeks significantly outweigh the difficult ones, and none of the difficult ones were treated as a reason to stop entirely.

If you take nothing else from this guide, take this: you don't need to be perfect to succeed. You need to be willing to keep returning to the plan, without drama, without punishment, and without waiting for a symbolic restart day, every single time life gets in the way. That's not a lesser version of discipline. That's what discipline that actually lasts looks like.



Emily Gray

Clinical Exercise Physiologist & Myotherapist. She's coached 450+ women through sustainable weight loss, and built Fitness By Em to give women the personalised, evidence-based coaching the fitness industry usually skips.

READY FOR MORE?

Work with Emily 1:1

Breaking a pattern you've lived inside for years is genuinely hard to do entirely alone, having someone who notices when you've gone quiet, checks in, and helps you get back on track without judgement makes an enormous difference.

That kind of ongoing support is exactly what coaching provides.

Book a free 30-minute call to talk through the patterns that have kept you stuck, and what breaking that cycle could actually look like with the right support in your corner.

Book a free call: calendly.com/emilygray81099/free-30min-consult-call
Instagram: instagram.com/_fitnessbyem_
Website: fitnessbyem.com.au

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